pharmaceuticals, agricultural products, and engineering goods – it has failed to make inroads into the Chinese market. Chinese buyers simply do not see Indian products as competitive.[55] Shockingly, in surveys conducted between 2000 and 2010, Chinese consumers identify the Indian economy at the bottom of a list of significant economies. While the US and Japan top the list, Patil notes that India comes in below North Korea and Pakistan. Clearly, this reflects China's close alliance-like relationship with the two countries. Yet the cognitive disconnect between the reality of the Indian economy and its significance in the perception of Chinese consumers is oceanic.[56]

Chinese dismissiveness extends to India's military and strategic importance. Throughout her stay in China, Patil asks if India is regarded as an enemy or a friend. The response usually consists of 'uncomfortable silences, blank stares, frowns and skyward gazes'. India apparently does not merit either category! Mention of the 1962 war does not excite much interest either. Here and there, particularly among the military or in the strategic community, there is a view that India needs to be taught a 'lesson' again, as in 1962.[57] A fairly widespread view is that its great power pretensions are just that – a mere 'figment of the imagination'.[58] A student engages Patil in conversation: 'your national day parades . . . in China we roll out impressive tanks and soldiers smartly holding guns . . . but your soldiers hold their rifles backward'. On a Chinese internet site, India's military modernization is described as 'loud thunder, tiny rain' and its forces on parade as looking like 'dancing clowns'.[59] The *Global Times*, the hard-line English-language newspaper, intones that 'India needs to consider whether or not it can afford the consequences of a potential confrontation with China'.[60] The newspaper will repeat the warning during the 2020 confrontation in Ladakh.

Patil's account of her China days does feature admirers of India – or at least of (some) Indians and things Indian. Tagore and Gandhi still attract Chinese interest and respect (Nehru does not). The Nobel laureate's works continue to be read: as late as 1985, a translation of his *Glimpses of Bengal* is sold out in a day in a Beijing bookstore. Patil's encounter with a Tagore